



Barrier Breakers, March 20, 2026. Students from across Northeast Ohio before the first pitch of the morning.

Reach 8,000 students. Put the top 250 in one room.

Barrier Breakers is FinMango's one-day innovation challenge for Northeast Ohio high schoolers. In 2026, powered by Valmark, we promoted it to roughly **8,000 students in 25+ high schools** through our in-person classroom programming across the academic year. About **250 of the top students** from those classrooms showed up on March 20 to pitch real solutions to the costs that hold families back.

~8,000

Students reached in person across 25+ high schools over the academic year, where the event was promoted

~250

Top students from those classrooms who competed on event day

\$20K+

Cash awarded to student teams, funded by Valmark and our 2026 sponsors

How the pipeline worked

In the classroom. FinMango teaches in-person financial education in 25+ Northeast Ohio high schools, reaching about 8,000 students across the academic year. That is where students first hear about Barrier Breakers.

The build. Teams of one to three pick a real barrier, such as transportation, housing, healthcare, or financial literacy, and build a solution to bring to the event.

Event day. Sixty-second pitches to a three-judge panel in the morning. Five finalists present to the whole room at Demo Day in the afternoon, and the cash goes to the teams.

2026 at a glance

Event date	March 20, 2026
Students competing	~250
Platinum sponsor	Valmark · \$25,000
Cash awarded	\$20,000+
Demo Day finalists	5 teams
1st place prize	\$7,500 to the team
Minimum finalist prize	\$1,250

Valmark on the day

Valmark was the presenting sponsor of Barrier Breakers 2026 and was visible to every student in the building, from check-in through the awards.

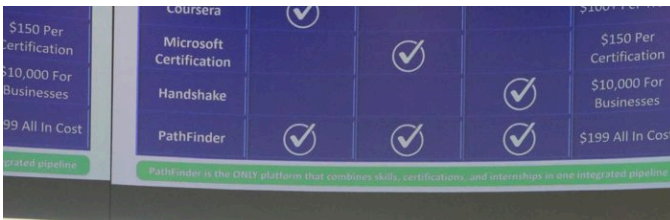
- \$25,000 platinum sponsorship funded the prize pool
- Two Valmark judges on the Demo Day panel
- Valmark table and banner on the gallery floor all day
- Valmark judges presented awards alongside the panel



Valmark's table on the gallery floor, where students stopped between judging rounds.



The gallery round: sixty seconds to make the case, then questions from a judge.



Demo Day: five finalists present for five minutes each in front of every student in the room.



Awards: cash to the teams and a handshake from the judges, including Valmark's.